THE GREAT NORTHERN WAR

FOUGHT BETWEEN 1700 and 1721, the Great Northern War was a contest between Sweden and a coalition of other countries determined to end Swedish domination of the Baltic region. Russia under Tsar Peter the Great and Denmark-Norway—at that time united under the Danish crown—were Sweden's major opponents at sea. The naval battles, which were contested by a mix of deep-sea sailing fleets and inshore galley fleets, mostly centered on the need for both sides to reinforce and resupply land forces fighting around the shores of the Baltic and North Sea. Through roughly the first decade of the war Sweden had the upper hand, but a series of defeats inflicted both by the Russians and by Denmark-Norway decisively turned the tide in the second half of the conflict. The overall outcome of the war was to establish Russia as a significant European naval and land power at the expense of Sweden.



THE GREAT NORTHERN WAR 1700–1721

Sweden's chief rival was Peter the Great's Russia, which gained a toehold in the Baltic with the founding of the city of St. Petersburg in 1702. By the end of the war a newly confident Russia was well established in the region with significant territorial gains around the Baltic coast. Sweden also lost all its possessions in Germany, mainly to another emergent power, Brandenburg-Prussia.

KEY

- Sweden
- Russia
- Denmark
- Borders 1700
- Russian gains from Sweden by 1721
- Russian victory over Sweden
- Danish victory over Sweden
- Inconclusive action

THE GREAT NORTHERN WAR

GANGUT



Date August 7, 1714
Forces Russians: c.100 galleys; Swedish: 1 pram, 6 galleys, 3 smaller boats
Losses Russians: 1 galley captured; Swedish: all ships lost

Location Hanko Peninsula, Finland

In summer 1714 Russian tsar Peter the Great's army was campaigning in Finland. The Russians wanted to open a line of supply and reinforcement to their land forces by sea, but the presence of the Swedish fleet off southern Finland blocked the passage of their vessels out of the Gulf of Finland.

In July Admiral Fyodor Apraksin led a strong force of galleys packed with soldiers as far as the Hanko Peninsula—known as Gangut to the Russians—where Swedish Vice Admiral Gustav Wattrang was waiting with 15 ships of the line supported by galleys and other smaller vessels. The Russians also had a sailing fleet commanded by the tsar himself, but Peter shifted to a galley, intending to mastermind the outflanking of the Swedish ships. The Russians planned to drag their galleys overland across the peninsula and refloat them behind the Swedish line, thus slipping through to join the army to the northwest. Gaining word of this plan, Wattrang sent Rear Admiral Nils Ehrenskjold with the pram *Elefant*—a shallow-draft ship with heavy guns—and a few galleys and skerries (rowing boats) to attack the Russian galleys as they reached the northern shore of the peninsula.

MAIDEN VICTORY

Unfortunately for Ehrenskjold, the Russians changed their plan. Taking advantage of a dead calm, Apraksin rowed his galleys past the flanks of the line of Swedish sailing ships, which were unable to move or bring guns to bear. Only one Russian galley ran aground and was captured. The swarm of galleys then fell upon Ehrenskjold's isolated squadron. The Swedish admiral arranged his ships across a narrow channel with *Elefant* in the center, broadside on to the enemy, and his galleys on the flanks. In the limited space the Russians could not bring all their galleys into the battle at once and *Elefant*'s guns drove off two attacks. On the third occasion, however, the Russians focused on the flanks, boarding the Swedish galleys with so many men that one was swamped and sank. Isolated and surrounded, *Elefant* was on fire with her admiral wounded. She surrendered as Russians swarmed aboard from all sides.

The Swedish lost 361 men killed on the spot, and about 400 more died of their wounds in Russian captivity. Russian dead and wounded numbered 466. Gangut was the first victory of the Russian Navy and allowed the tsar's fleet to operate freely in support of the land forces in Finland.



Closing in for the kill
Among the islands and narrow straits of the Baltic coast, oared galleys could often get the better of large sailing ships. At Gangut the Russian galleys scored a notable victory, even though it was against a much smaller and isolated Swedish force.